AI Tool Prompt Engineering Report

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AI Tool Overview

I chose Claude as the AI assistant for this laboratory for a number of reasons, but it really comes down to one thing it just works, and it works well. Claude is safe, versatile, and consistently delivers high-quality results across a wide variety of tasks, from writing and analysis to coding and research support.

On a day-to-day basis, I use it for tasks like breaking down long, complex documents into clear, digestible summaries, drafting well-structured content, tracking down bugs in code, and thinking through ideas during brainstorming sessions. It handles natural language remarkably well, which makes conversations feel less like issuing commands to a machine and more like working through a problem with a knowledgeable colleague.

What also sets Claude apart is its commitment to being a responsible and trustworthy assistant. It doesn't just generate fast responses; it generates thoughtful ones. That kind of reliability matters a lot in a laboratory setting where accuracy and careful reasoning are non-negotiable.

And honestly, after trying out several AI tools, Claude simply produces some of the best outputs I've come across. The clarity, depth, and consistency of its responses have made it an easy and confident choice as the go-to AI assistant for this lab.

Original Prompt

First, introduce the members of the Justice League, starting with the DC Trinity (Superman, Batman, Wonder Woman); then introduce Darkseid and his goons, and give their history of battles across the comic book canon.

Then give me a rundown of the rivalry between Darkseid and the Justice League that led to the creation of the absolute universe. Make sure to keep notes during the storytelling that Superman is the embodiment of hope in the DC universe, while Darkseid is the embodiment of Pure Evil. And end it with what is currently happening in the Absolute Universe and what happened in DC K.O.

Keep it brief and concise.

ClaudeAI Output:

The DC Trinity — Pillars of the Justice League

- **Superman - Kal-El / Clark Kent :** Last son of Krypton. The most powerful hero alive — and DC's eternal symbol that goodness can prevail in any darkness.
- **Batman - Bruce Wayne:** The World's Greatest Detective. No powers — only will, intellect, and an unbreakable oath to fight evil born from personal tragedy.
- **Wonder Woman - Diana Prince:** Amazon warrior princess. Blessed by the gods, she wields truth, justice, and compassion as weapons as deadly as any blade.

The Full League:

- **The Flash - Barry Allen:** Fastest man alive; taps the Speed Force to bend time itself.
- **Green Lantern - Hal Jordan:** Space cop armed with a willpower-fueled ring that can build anything imaginable.
- **Aquaman - Arthur Curry:** King of Atlantis; commands the seas and every creature within them.
- **Cyborg - Victor Stone:** Half-human, half-machine; his body is fused with a Mother Box — Apokolips technology turned against its maker.
- **Martian Manhunter - J'onn J'onzz:** The League's telepathic heart; last survivor of Mars, shapeshifter and empath.
- **Hawkgirl - Shiera Hall:** Reincarnated Thanagarian warrior bearing wings, a Nth metal mace, and millennia of combat memory.

Darkseid and the Forces of Apokolips - Pure Evil Incarnate

- **Darkseid - Uxas, Lord of Apokolips -** A New God who murdered his brother and absorbed the Omega Force. He seeks the Anti-Life Equation — a mathematical proof that free will is an illusion — to enslave every conscious mind in existence. He does not want to conquer. He wants to unmake hope itself.
- **Granny Goodness -** Head of the orphanages of Apokolips; tortures children into becoming Darkseid's Furies.
- **Desaad -** Darkseid's chief torturer and weapons engineer; delights in cruelty.
- **Kalibak -** Darkseid's brutish son; a blunt instrument of destruction.
- **Steppenwolf -** Darkseid's uncle and supreme military commander; leads invasions with Mother Box technology.
- **Parademons -** Mindless shock troops — dead soldiers reanimated into winged horrors of pure aggression.

Battles Across the Comic Canon

New Gods #1 - 1971 Jack Kirby's Fourth World

- Darkseid and the New Gods are introduced. The war between New Genesis and Apokolips begins — Darkseid's obsession with the Anti-Life Equation established from day one.

Super Powers - 1984 -First Mass Invasion

- Darkseid marshals Apokolips against Earth's heroes. Superman and the League repel the invasion — but Darkseid's cold patience ensures every defeat is merely a delay.

Great Darkness - 1982 - The Great Darkness Saga

- In the 30th century, a resurrected Darkseid mind-controls entire worlds. The Legion of Super-Heroes must stop a god reclaiming his dominion over all existence.

Final Crisis - 2008 - Darkseid Falls — And Wins

- Darkseid successfully broadcasts the Anti-Life Equation across Earth, enslaving humanity. Superman — Hope itself — is the only one who can reverse it. Batman fires a god-killing bullet at Darkseid, while Darkseid's Omega Beams kill Batman. The universe barely survives.

Darkseid War - 2015–16 -Darkseid vs. the Anti-Monitor

- Darkseid is killed by the Anti-Monitor. His death fractures reality. Several Justice Leaguers absorb aspects of his power — Flash becomes the Black Racer, Lex Luthor proclaims himself the new Darkseid.

Endgame / R&R -2019–22 - Perpetua, Apex Lex & the Death Metal

- Darkseid returns, pulling strings behind the scenes during Scott Snyder's Justice League run. He seeks the Totality — the source energy of the universe. Superman's undying hope becomes the weapon that defeats Perpetua and resets creation.

The Rivalry That Created the Absolute Universe

The breaking point: Dawn of DC / New 52 fatigue

- By 2023, decades of Darkseid invasions, Crisis events, and reboots had left DC's continuity fractured. Each time Darkseid nearly extinguished hope, the universe was reset — but the resets themselves began eroding meaning. Readers and creators alike felt the weight of a cosmos perpetually on the brink.

The Absolute Universe (2024–present)

- DC launched an entirely separate continuity — raw, stripped-back, and redesigned from the ground up. The premise: what if the heroes never had the privilege of hope? Superman is not a beacon from a loving family — he is a desperate immigrant, learning what hope even means. Batman is not a billionaire—he is working-class, fueled by rage. Wonder Woman is colonized and fighting back. Pure Evil has already won a round. The Absolute Universe is DC asking: "What does hope look like when it has already been crushed once?"

Superman as Hope

- In the Absolute Universe, Kal-El's hope is not a birthright — it is earned under conditions designed to destroy it. This makes him, paradoxically, the most powerful symbol of hope DC has ever published. Darkseid, as Pure Evil, is the pressure that forges him.

Absolute Universe (2025–26)

Absolute Power arc

- The Absolute Universe continues with Absolute Superman, Absolute Batman, and Absolute Wonder Woman as flagship titles. The heroes are still assembling — forming a Justice League that has never existed before in this universe. Darkseid looms as the existential threat these broken, reconstructed heroes are being forged to face. The stakes are higher because hope here was never guaranteed.

DC K.O. — The Elseworlds Brawl

- DC K.O. is a non-canon, ultra-violent Elseworlds storyline where DC heroes and villains are pitted in brutal, no-rules combat scenarios — essentially a "what if the gloves came all the way off" tournament arc. Characters fight beyond their usual limits; deaths that would never stick in mainline continuity are played for visceral impact. It exists outside both the main DC universe and the Absolute Universe, serving as a raw celebration of power fantasy and spectacle.

AI-Assisted Prompt Using ClaudeAI:

You are a DC Comics lore expert and storyteller. Present the following as a cohesive, cinematic narrative — not a list or encyclopedia entry.

Act 1 — The Justice League: Introduce the members of the Justice League. Begin with the DC Trinity (Superman, Batman, Wonder Woman) as the emotional and symbolic core. Throughout the entire narrative, treat **Superman as the living embodiment of Hope** — the DC universe's answer to despair — and let that theme breathe in how you describe him. Then introduce the rest of the League.

Act 2 — The Enemy: Introduce Darkseid and his inner circle (Granny Goodness, Desaad, Kalibak, Steppenwolf, Parademons). Frame **Darkseid as Pure Evil incarnate** — not a villain who wants power, but one who wants to *extinguish hope itself* through the Anti-Life Equation. Trace their battles against the Justice League across the comic book canon (key arcs: Fourth World, Final Crisis, Darkseid War, Death Metal).

Act 3 — The Breaking Point: Narrate how the unending cycle of cosmic war and universal resets between the Justice League and Darkseid accumulated enough narrative and emotional weight to necessitate a new universe. Connect this thematically to the Superman/Hope vs. Darkseid/Pure Evil dynamic.

Act 4 — The Absolute Universe & DC K.O.: Briefly cover what is currently unfolding in the Absolute Universe. Then give a concise rundown of what happened in DC K.O.

Tone: Epic, grounded, and purposeful. Think HBO prestige drama meets cosmic mythology. Keep it brief and concise — no padding.

ClaudeAI Output:

Act 1

The Justice League — Guardians of Hope

There is a moment in almost every DC story where it seems like the darkness will win. The city is burning. The universe is fracturing. The math says it's over. And then he arrives — not because he's the most powerful, but because he refuses to stop believing it can be otherwise. Superman is not the Justice League's strongest weapon. He is the reason. He is the living proof, in a universe that keeps trying to disprove it, that hope is not naïve. It is the only force that has ever actually saved anything.

He is the DC universe's answer to every argument that evil makes. The counterpoint that never breaks.

Embodiment of hope

1. **Superman — Kal-El**
    - Last son of Krypton. Raised in Kansas to believe that power is only meaningful when it serves others. His greatest strength was never his fists — it was the fact that he never, not once, stopped hoping. Where Darkseid brings the Anti-Life Equation, Superman is the living counter-proof.
2. **Batman — Bruce Wayne**
    - The World's Greatest Detective. No powers. No mercy for injustice. Born from personal tragedy, he is the League's iron nerve — the one who plans for failure so the mission never does. The strategist who keeps the dream operational when idealism isn't enough.
3. **Wonder Woman — Diana Prince**
    - Amazon warrior princess, blessed by the gods of Olympus. She carries truth and compassion as weapons sharper than any blade. The Trinity's moral spine — older than civilization, fiercer than war, and the first to charge when everything looks hopeless.
4. **The Flash — Barry Allen**
    - Fastest man alive. Taps the Speed Force to outrun time itself. Where Superman embodies hope, Barry embodies sacrifice — he has literally run himself out of existence to save the universe.
5. **Green Lantern — Hal Jordan**
    - Space cop of Sector 2814. His ring runs on willpower — it turns belief into physical reality. The universe's police force, made manifest.
6. **Aquaman — Arthur Curry**
    - King of Atlantis. Commands the seven seas and every creature within them. A ruler who fights not for conquest but for the survival of worlds beneath and above the surface.
7. **Cyborg — Victor Stone**
    - Half-human, half-Mother Box. Apokolips' technology repurposed against its own creators. His very existence is a rebuke of Darkseid's claim that technology enslaves.
8. **Martian Manhunter — J'onn J'onzz**
    - The League's telepathic heart. The last of Mars. He has felt the genocide of his species firsthand, and chose compassion over vengeance. That choice is the League's soul.

Act 2

Darkseid and the Armies of Apokolips

On the other side of the Source Wall, there is a planet that burns. Apokolips — a world of fire pits and subjugation, where hope has been systematically eradicated for millennia. At its center sits Darkseid, and he is not simply a powerful villain. He is the theological opposite of everything Superman represents. He does not want to conquer. Conquerors still believe the conquered have value. Darkseid wants to prove that free will was always an illusion — and he has the equation to do it.

The Anti-Life Equation is not a weapon. It is proof. A mathematical argument that hope, love, and self-determination were never real. That everything Superman stands for is a lie.

Pure evil incarnate

1. **Darkseid — Uxas, Lord of Apokolips**
    - A New God who killed his own brother to seize the Omega Force. He does not rage or desire. He calculates. Every invasion, every war, every act of cosmic cruelty is one step in a patient, eternal proof: that hope is a chemical accident, and he has the formula to end it forever.
2. **Granny Goodness**
    - Runs the orphanages of Apokolips. She takes children and breaks them into soldiers — the Female Furies — through love twisted into weaponized abuse.
3. **Desaad**
    - Darkseid's torturer-in-chief and weapons engineer. Where Darkseid is cold, Desaad is gleeful. He is what happens when cruelty is given a title.
4. **Kalibak**
    - Darkseid's brutish son. Pure violence given form. The blunt instrument sent when finesse is not required — which, for Apokolips, is often.
5. **Steppenwolf**
    - Supreme military commander. He invades worlds ahead of Darkseid's arrival, shattering planetary defenses with Mother Box technology turned into weapons of conquest.
6. **Parademons**
    - Dead soldiers. Reanimated corpses of the fallen, turned into mindless, winged shock troops. Darkseid's armies are literally built from the bodies of those who dared resist him.

The battles between Darkseid and the Justice League span decades of canon — each one a variation on the same cosmic argument: can hope survive contact with a force designed specifically to extinguish it?

Jack Kirby, 1971 - Fourth World

The origin. Darkseid, the New Gods, and the war between New Genesis and Apokolips. The Anti-Life Equation was introduced as the conflict's true prize — not planets, but the concept of free will itself.

1982 - The Great Darkness Saga

A resurrected Darkseid mind-controls entire civilizations across the 30th century. Even 1,000 years in the future, the shadow of Apokolips has not faded. The Legion of Super-Heroes is the last line between him and the universe.

Grant Morrison, 2008 - Final Crisis

Darkseid's masterwork. He broadcasts the Anti-Life Equation across Earth — and it works. Humanity falls. Superman is pulled to the edge of the universe. Batman fires a god-killing bullet. Darkseid fires his Omega Beams. Both land. The universe nearly ends. Superman returns and sings reality back together with a chord of pure hope.

Johns/Fabok, 2015 - Darkseid War

Darkseid faces the Anti-Monitor and dies. His death fractures the structure of the DC cosmos. Several Leaguers absorb his power — Flash becomes the Black Racer, death incarnate. Lex Luthor crowns himself the new Darkseid. Power without purpose accelerates decay.

Snyder, 2020 -Death Metal

Darkseid pulls strings from behind a collapsing multiverse. The Batman Who Laughs nearly unmakes everything. Superman's hope, weaponized as literal narrative energy — the "Elseworlds energy" of infinite possibility — is the force that resets creation and opens the door to Infinite Frontier.

Act 3

The Breaking Point — When the Universe Needed to Start Over

By the early 2020s, something had calcified. Readers could feel it. Every cosmic crisis ended with a reset. Every death was undone. Every time Darkseid came within reach of proving his thesis — that hope was meaningless — Superman found a way to reverse it, and the universe restarted. The problem was that the resets were starting to feel like Darkseid's argument made flesh. If nothing ever permanently changes, does hope mean anything?

The creative pressure became philosophical. DC had been running the same engine — hope vs. annihilation, Superman vs. the end of everything — for fifty years. The engine still worked. But the weight of continuity had become its own kind of Anti-Life Equation: a proof, accumulated through decades of reboots, that the universe itself was trapped, that no choice had permanent stakes, and that the heroes were essentially immortal bureaucrats managing an unchangeable status quo.

Darkseid had never needed to win outright. He just needed the heroes to stop believing their victories meant anything. And slowly, through accumulated reset after reset, that's exactly what was happening — to the characters, and to the audience.

The answer DC arrived at was not another Crisis. It was a rupture. A separate universe, built on the premise that hope is not a default setting — it has to be earned from scratch, under conditions designed to destroy it. That universe became the Absolute Universe.

Act 4

The Absolute Universe and DC K.O.

Absolute Universe — 2024 to present

The Absolute Universe is DC's most radical creative bet in decades. It is not a reboot of the main continuity — it runs alongside it as a separate, parallel cosmos. The premise: what if the heroes never had the safety net of a universe that fundamentally believed in them? What if hope had to be built from ruin?

1. **Absolute Superman**
    - Kal-El lands on Earth as a desperate refugee, not a celebrated savior. He is not raised in warmth and Kansas cornfields — he has to discover what hope means in a world that gives him no reason to have any. This makes him, paradoxically, the most powerful embodiment of hope DC has ever published.
2. **Absolute Batman**
    - Bruce Wayne is not a billionaire. He is working class, radicalized by loss, operating without the luxury of a cave full of resources. The oath is the same. The cost is much higher.
3. **Absolute Wonder Woman**
    - Diana is not an emissary from paradise — she emerges from a world under siege, a warrior forged by colonization and resistance. Her compassion is harder-won and, therefore, more powerful.

The Absolute Justice League is still assembling. Darkseid looms as the existential threat these versions of the heroes have been broken and rebuilt specifically to face. The dramatic stakes are higher because nothing about hope is guaranteed here — and that's exactly the point.

DC K.O.

DC K.O. is something entirely different — and deliberately so. It is a non-canon, Elseworlds brawl series that exists outside both the main DC universe and the Absolute Universe. The premise is pure spectacle: what if the gloves came off entirely? Heroes and villains are pitted in brutal, no-rules combat with no continuity protection. Death's land with weight. Power levels are pushed beyond their narrative ceilings. Characters who would never be killed in mainline continuity can and do fall.

It is not lore. It is not mythology. It is DC as a heavyweight prize fight—a visceral celebration of power fantasy, consequences, and spectacle for its own sake. And as a pressure valve for a universe otherwise defined by meaningful stakes and earned hope, it serves its purpose well.

Comparison and Analysis:

Two prompts. Same request. Completely different results — and the gap between them is worth understanding.

The original prompt knew what it wanted. It named the right characters, flagged the right arcs, and reminded Claude to keep the Superman/hope and Darkseid/evil themes in mind. That's not nothing. But what it produced was essentially a very well-organized encyclopedia entry — accurate, complete, and lifeless. Think of it like ordering a meal by listing every ingredient you want included. You'll get all the ingredients. Nobody said anything about cooking.

The problems with the original output came down to three things:

- It was a checklist, so it produced an inventory. Characters appeared as entries rather than forces. Battles were summaries rather than consequences. The Anti-Life Equation was described as a superpower instead of what it actually is — a philosophical argument that free will was always a lie.
- The thematic core never landed. The Superman/hope vs. Darkseid/evil dynamic was mentioned, but it never moved anything. It sat in the text like a footnote rather than driving the narrative like an engine.
- There was no architecture. Without a dramatic structure, each section existed beside the others rather than building on them. The whole never became greater than the sum of its parts.

The improved prompt fixed all three — not by adding more information, but by changing the operating conditions. This aligns with what researchers have found about prompt engineering more broadly: prompts allow seamless integration of pre-trained models into downstream tasks by eliciting desired model behaviors solely based on the given prompt arXiv — meaning the

quality of the output is largely a function of how well the prompt communicates intent, context, and structure (Sahoo et al., 2024).

- Assigning a role ("DC lore expert and storyteller") shifted Claude's posture from retrieval to authorship. It's the difference between asking someone to recite a story and asking them to tell it.
- Structuring it into four dramatic acts gave the content a direction. Each act had to earn its place by building on the last, which meant the Absolute Universe, by the time it arrived, felt inevitable rather than arbitrary.
- Elevating the thematic notes into active instructions ("let that theme breathe," "not a villain who wants power, but one who wants to extinguish hope itself") gave Claude a thesis to argue rather than a fact to report. That single change is responsible for most of the difference in emotional weight between the two outputs.

The place where the gap shows most clearly is Act 3 — the Breaking Point. The original prompt barely touched it. The improved prompt insisted it be treated as the emotional hinge of the entire piece: the moment where decades of resets stopped feeling like victories and started feeling like Darkseid's argument made real. That one reframe turned the Absolute Universe from a publishing decision into a creative inevitability.

The tone directive mattered more than it might seem, too. "HBO prestige drama meets cosmic mythology" is not decoration — it told Claude that this audience takes the material seriously, that the grandeur should feel earned, and that every sentence needs to carry weight. It set the register before a single word was written.

The lesson, put plainly: a prompt that tells Claude what to cover produces reference material. A prompt that tells Claude how to think about what it's covering produces storytelling. The content

was always there. The prompt determined whether it would lie flat on the page or actually breathe.

Reference:

Sahoo, P., Singh, A. K., Saha, S., Jain, V., Mondal, S., & Chadha, A. (2024). *A systematic survey of prompt engineering in large language models: Techniques and applications.* arXiv. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2402.07927